



Mantle

A GIANT CLAM

The giant blue clam grows to about 1 ft (30 cm) long, but the largest giant clams may reach over 3 ft (1 m). The colorful mantle exposed at the edge of their shells contains hordes of single-celled algae that make their own food by using the energy from sunlight. The clam absorbs nutrients from the growing crop of algae.

Life on a coral reef

CORAL REEFS HAVE an amazing variety of marine life, from teeming multitudes of brightly colored fish to giant clams wedged into rocks. Every bit of space on the reef provides a hiding place or shelter for some animal or plant. At night, a host of amazing creatures emerge from coral caves and crevices to feed. All the living organisms on the reef depend for their survival on

the stony corals which recycle the scarce nutrients from the clear, blue, tropical waters. People, as well as animals, rely on coral reefs for they protect coastlines, attract tourists' money, and some island nations live on coral atolls. Sadly, in spite of being one of the great natural wonders of the world, coral reefs are now under threat. Destruction is caused by reefs being broken up for building materials, damaged by snorkelers and divers touching or treading on them, dynamited by fishermen, ripped up by souvenir collectors, covered by soil eroded by the destruction of rain forests, and polluted by sewage and oil spills.

Green color helps camouflage sea slug among seaweeds



Tentacles of sea anemone covered with stings to put off predators

Large eye for keeping a watch for danger

The clown fish's slimy coat does not trigger the anemone's stings

FRILLY LETTUCE

Sea slugs are related to sea snails but do not have shells. Many sea slugs living on coral reefs feed on corals, but the lettuce slug feeds on algae growing on the reef by sucking the sap from individual cells. Chloroplasts, the green part of plant cells, are then stored in the slug's digestive system where they continue to trap energy from sunlight to make food. Many other reef sea slugs are brightly colored to warn that they are dangerous and recycle the stings that they eat from the coral's tentacles.

Side fin used to steer and change direction

Stripes break up clown fish's outline, perhaps making it more difficult for predators to see the fish on the reef

LIVING IN HARMONY

Clown fish which shelter in anemones live on coral reefs in the Pacific and Indian Oceans. Unlike other fish, clown fish are not stung by their anemone home. The anemone's stings are not triggered because chemicals taken from the anemone are carried in the clown fish's slimy coat. Clown fish seldom venture far from their anemone home for fear of attack by other fish. There are different kinds of clown fish, some living only with certain kinds of anemones.